

HIDE TO FIND
Labourers process hides at the Kolkata Leather Complex

Photographs by DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

COW VIGILANTISM, THE CLOSURE OF SLAUGHTERHOUSES IN 2017 AND OF TANNERIES IN 2019 FORCED UP'S TANNERS TO LOOK FOR ALTERNATIVE BUSINESS LOCATIONS. THE INFRASTRUCTURE AT KLC MET THEIR NEEDS

the Kumbh Mela in January 2019, the Uttar Pradesh Pollution Control Board passed an order asking tanneries to shut down for three months to stop the discharge of effluents in the Ganga. Hundreds of tanneries closed down, and foreign contracts cancelled. As tannery owners turned to Pakistan and Bangladesh for raw material, manufacturers started looking to Kolkata to move or open new production units. The reasons? A metropolis with an airport and access to a port, cheap labour, but mostly government sops and attractive land rates at the KLC.

"There were several hundred tanners asking for land," says Naaz. "But Didi chose only those who were serious about the leather industry, not those who were looking to use it for other purposes," he says.

Indeed, the West Bengal government has been serious about giving the labour-intensive leather industry a big push by scaling up infrastructure, upgrading effluent treatment plants and promising a conducive environment. It was not a surprise, therefore, that many Kanpur tanners started contemplating setting up new units at KLC.

Their endeavours, however, were rudely interrupted by the Covid-19 pandemic, and the debilitating lockdowns that accompanied it, having a crippling effect on the industry and slowing down the entire process of the actual physical relocation from Kanpur. As matters stand, over 30 tanners from the city have been allocated space in KLC and are in the process of moving in, with their units in various stages of construction.

"We took possession of land only a few months back...it was delayed mainly because of Covid and for